

EPISODE 13 (SESSION 1)

Grappling with God, Part 1

PRIMARY TEXT: GENESIS 25, 27–31

Why does God choose to work with the people that He does in His Story?

We've looked at Adam and Eve. Cain and Abel. Noah. Shem and Ham. Then God chooses Abraham, and we can imagine this is due to his willingness to sacrifice his own legacy, his habit of showing radical hospitality, and his overall faithfulness in trusting the Story. Not perfect by any means—but we see so many instances of why God would choose him.

Then there's Jacob. The “deceiver,” “overreacher,” “usurper.” A man who seems to lack redeeming qualities so far in his story of grappling with God.

Why does God want to work with Jacob?

Why does God continue to work with Jacob?

Why is God so stupidly gracious to Jacob over and over again?

Jacob lies and deceives and burns people around him with his fiery persona more than once. Why can't he just chill and be content?

Perhaps it's because God is looking for people who are going to DO something. Sometimes God needs those with fire and *chutzpah*. Those who are willing and ready to, like Abraham, let go and get going. Those who are not just content, but those who, in their unsustainable ways, experience God so much more intimately than those who are too content to hear God call them to something different ever will.

**God is looking
for people who
are going to do
something.**

Sometimes we are faced with similar questions about ourselves.

Why would God want to work with me?

Why does God continue to work with us?

Why is God so stupidly gracious with humanity over and over again?!

**We miss out on
sitting at the
precipice of truly
experiencing God**

Maybe there is something to Reed's idea that the more we experience God—the less we “know.” Maybe we are all too content with “knowledge” of our birthright and our so-called place in the family that we miss out on sitting at the precipice of truly and intimately experiencing God once in a while.

Jacob was most definitely not perfect. Neither were his forefathers, and neither are we. But he had *chutzpah* that God could use, and God was there from the beginning to the end whether Jacob recognized His presence throughout the journey or not.

**God can use
anyone...**

Perhaps the point of stories like this is not figuring out who you are—a Jacob or an Esau—but to see how God can use anyone if, when you're in the middle of nowhere's nowhere and you hear His voice, you listen. Letting that transform you again and again.

We can realize that our plans, our ways of pursuing a promise of what we think is best, are unsustainable. We cannot do life in our own ways, no matter how passionate we may be, and expect not to have to flee from our mistakes. To expect not to hurt people along the way. But we can be and do good. We can choose goodness. We can choose to use our *chutzpah* to do the next right thing—and that is because we are created in His image and blessed from the beginning as of the “very good.”

PRAYER

*God,
We bless you for your grace.
Your radical grace
when we misjudge your promises
with our own plans and misguided words.
In the middle of or rock bottom of
nowhere's nowhere, you remind us
that you are here and have been all along.
Thank you for still pursuing and partnering with us
to carry out your promise and bless the world
with Your grace and love.
May we never stop.*

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 13

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

How could you meditate over these parts of the Story? What Text could you continue to meditate on, memorize, or dig deeper into?



COMMUNITY

In what ways does your community encourage your chutzpah, yet hold you accountable? How could authentic community contribute to healthy fire and chutzpah that God can use?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who in your life would benefit from a mentor-like relationship? Someone with fire like Jacob or more complacent like Esau? What might the young people around you need to hear or see modeled for them to hear God's calling?



WRESTLING

What questions do you have after this lesson? Why Jacob? Why me? Why use this family line after all of this? What do you still struggle with when it comes to Jacob, his mother's role in the schemes, Isaac's supposed naivety, or Esau's laziness? What sits uncomfortably still?



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE *SPIRITUAL FORMATION*

*We believe that **if we do our part of creating space for God, He will fill it.** We want BEMA to foster practices that enable the Holy Spirit to do a work in and through us all—whether we feel a little more like Jacob, Esau, or a bit in between in this story. How have you, or could you, create a space that God can fill so you are more willing and able to hear His voice or trust the next step in YOUR story? Different spiritual disciplines or discipleship? You never know when God may lead you somewhere new or will show you He’s been in that space all along.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS *YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS*

We believe young adults are shaping the future of this world, and they need the blessings and care of people like you. In what ways could you come alongside young adults to show them they are valued and loved no matter what personality traits they have? How might someone like you coming alongside them help them look for God in the middle of nowhere’s nowhere or right at home?

SACRED STATION *THEOLOGY OF WORK*

*This may be about what we do at work—but it’s also about the individuals we interact with each day. Do we carry the promise to bless the world with us always, or only when it is convenient or safe? Do we choose to lie and deceive to gain our promises or security? Or do we trust that God has been here all along? Trusting the Story? How does this impact those we interact with in the office, the home, the shop, the store, etc.? Are we willing to put others before ourselves and bless them or keep blessings for ourselves? **The work we do every day is sacred. It matters to the Kingdom!***